



Office of Public Affairs
U.S. Department of Justice



Houston Pharmacy Owner Sentenced to 19 Years in Prison for Illegal Distribution of Opioids and Tax Fraud

Wednesday, May 21, 2025

For Immediate Release

Office of Public Affairs

A Texas man was sentenced on Monday to 19 years in prison for unlawfully conspiring to distribute millions of opioid pills and aiding the falsification of tax records.

According to court documents, Christopher Obaze, 64, of Houston, Texas, was the owner and pharmacist-in-charge of Chrisco Pharmacy. Obaze and his co-conspirators operated Chrisco Pharmacy as an illegal “ghosting pharmacy,” purchasing pharmaceutical opioids and other commonly abused prescription drugs from wholesalers and then selling them in bulk to drug traffickers, without involving physicians, patients, or prescriptions. From January 2018 through October 2021, Obaze and his co-conspirators distributed at least 2,268,700 hydrocodone 10-325 mg and oxycodone 30 mg pills as part of the scheme.

The defendant and his pharmacy technician attempted to conceal their illegal activities by reporting no dispensing of the drugs to the Texas State Board of Pharmacy’s prescription monitoring program after July 2018, and by structuring cash deposits and submitting false documents to banks to maintain accounts to hold the proceeds of their unlawful distribution scheme. Obaze also aided and assisted in the preparation and presentation of false and fraudulent tax returns to the IRS by understating, among other things, the gross receipts of Chrisco Pharmacy.

Matthew R. Galeotti, Head of the Justice Department’s Criminal Division, U.S. Attorney Nicholas J. Ganjei for the Southern District of Texas, Special Agent in Charge William Kimbell of the Drug Enforcement Administration (DEA) Houston Division, and Special Agent in Charge Lucy Tan of the IRS Criminal Investigation (IRS-CI) Houston Field Office made the announcement.

The DEA and IRS-CI investigated the case.

Trial Attorney Drew Pennebaker of the Criminal Division’s Fraud Section prosecuted the case.

The Fraud Section leads the Criminal Division’s efforts to combat health care fraud through the Health Care Fraud Strike Force Program. Since March 2007, this program, currently comprised of 9 strike forces operating in 27 federal districts, has charged more than 5,800 defendants who collectively have billed federal health care programs and private insurers more than \$30 billion. In addition, the Centers for Medicare & Medicaid Services, working in conjunction with the Office of the Inspector General for the Department of Health and Human Services, are taking steps to hold providers accountable for their involvement in health care fraud schemes. More information can be found at www.justice.gov/criminal/criminal-fraud/health-care-fraud-unit.

Updated June 23, 2025

Topics

- OPIOIDS
- HEALTHCARE FRAUD
- TAX

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